UNHEALTHY OUTING

Videos of RJD patriarch Lalu Yadav driving a jeep or playing badminton have been a hit on social media. There is no mistaking the message: the old war horse was back, and fighting fit for the Lok Sabha election battle in 2024. However, Lalu's latest outing on August 16, in which he took party vice president Shivanand Tiwari for a kulfi at Patna Ganga Path, has not really proved auspicious. Two days later, the Supreme Court acceded to the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) request for an early listing of their plea seeking the cancellation of Lalu's bail in the fodder scam. Now, some grand alliance leaders in Bihar are worried the CBI might use the same videos to claim that Lalu was fit for jail.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

WOOING KISHOR

A desperate **N. Chandrababu Naidu** is keen that election strategist **Prashant Kishor** comes to the aid of his Telegu Desam Party to turn the tables on Andhra Pradesh chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's YSR Congress. A wily Jagan has retained the Kishor-founded Indian Political Action Committee as consultant even after it had helped him win the 2019 election and is unlikely to let go. A never-say-die Naidu, who is determined to make the 2024 assembly poll a fight, still hopes to win Kishor over if the TDP fails to ally with the BJP in the coming months.



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UNDER PRESSURE



Bharat Gogawale, an **Eknath Shinde** loyalist, dropped a bombshell recently when he revealed that there was immense pressure on the Maharashtra chief minister when it came to choosing his ministers last year. Gogawale, who, incidentally, is still awaiting his inclusion in the council of ministers, claimed that an MLA was appointed as a minister because he had told Shinde that his wife was threatening to commit suicide if this was not done. Another MLA claimed that he had faced a threat from BJP leader Narayan Rane and yet another threatened to resign. Put together, this forced Shinde's hand, Gogawale claims.

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah, Dhaval Kulkarni and Amarnath K. Menon

SUPER SLEUTH

The Union government is likely to create a new post of **Chief Investigation Officer of India** (CIO) who will supervise the functioning of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and Enforcement Directorate (ED). The ED probes financial fraud, but the CBI also looks into cases of corruption and other offences. The view is that a CIO heading the two agencies, with their chiefs reporting to him, would bring better synergy. While the ED will remain under the finance ministry and CBI under the ministry of personnel, public grievances and pensions, the all-powerful CIO will report to the prime minister. Speculation is now rife on who will be the first CIO.

MP-MLA-Mayor Melee

Gujarat recently witnessed an ugly spat between Jamnagar MLA **Rivaba Jadeja** (wife of cricketer Ravindra Jadeja), Jamnagar MP **Poonamben Maadam** and Jamnagar mayor **Bina Kothari** (all from the BJP). At a municipal corporation event, Jadeja accused Maadam of passing a demeaning remark as she removed her footwear to pay tribute at a newly inaugurated martyrs' memorial. When Kothari tried to intervene, Jadeja ticked her off. As the video of the incident went viral, both sides tried to defend themselves, with Kothari even lodging a police complaint against Jadeja. Factionalism at every level?



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